

C963

American Politics and the US Constitution

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer _____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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Items

1.

A bill funding rural broadband, backed by a coalition of farm groups, is vetoed by the President. The House votes 300–130 to override, and the Senate votes 62–38. What happens?

- A. The bill becomes law, because both chambers voted by majority.
- B. The bill becomes law, because the House cleared two-thirds.
- C. The Supreme Court decides whether the veto stands.
- D. The veto stands, because the Senate fell short of two-thirds.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which is a check the federal courts hold over Congress?

- A. Confirming federal judges
- B. Rewriting any law the judges disagree with
- C. Vetoing a bill
- D. Declaring a law unconstitutional

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A state with the nation's 12th-largest economy, led by a governor in her second term, sets its own high school graduation requirements. Which type of power is the state using?

- A. An implied federal power
- B. A reserved power
- C. A concurrent power
- D. An enumerated power

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which of these is a concurrent power held by both the national and state governments?

- A. Setting up local governments
- B. Levying taxes
- C. Every power is shared equally between the levels.
- D. Coining money

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

A state legislature places a special tax only on a federal agency's regional office, which employs 140 people in a historic downtown building. The stated goal is to push the office out of the state. How would a court most likely rule?

- A. Strike the tax; under the Supremacy Clause a state cannot tax or obstruct valid federal operations.
- B. Strike it under the Full Faith and Credit Clause.
- C. Uphold it; the 10th Amendment lets states tax anything within their borders.
- D. Uphold it; the national government may only create offices listed in the Constitution.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

A public university founded in 1890, with a nationally ranked engineering program, refuses to admit qualified applicants from one ethnic group. What kind of constitutional issue is this?

- A. A civil liberties issue under free speech
- B. Not a constitutional issue, since universities have total control of admissions.
- C. A Fourth Amendment search issue
- D. A civil rights issue under equal protection

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which situation is a civil liberties issue rather than a civil rights issue?

- A. Any claim involving the Constitution is a civil liberty.
- B. A state law bars women from voting.
- C. Police search a home without a warrant or consent.
- D. An employer pays workers differently by sex.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

A state passes a law punishing newspapers that criticize the governor. A newspaper that has published since 1921 and circulates in two states challenges it. The state argues the First Amendment says only “Congress shall make no law.” What is the best response?

- A. The protection applies only because the paper circulates in two states.
- B. The state is right; the text names only Congress.
- C. The 14th Amendment’s Due Process Clause applies free-press protection to the states.
- D. The 10th Amendment gives the state authority over its press.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

The federal government asks a court to stop a newspaper, which has won three regional journalism awards, from publishing leaked documents about a past military policy. Officials say the story would embarrass the government. How is the court most likely to respond?

- A. Refuse; prior restraint faces a heavy presumption against it, and embarrassment does not meet that burden.
- B. Refuse, and the paper is immune from any later legal liability.
- C. Grant it, because publishing leaked documents is libel.
- D. Grant it; the government may block any publication of classified material.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

In a presidential election with 66% turnout, the highest in decades, one candidate wins the national popular vote by 2 million votes but loses the presidency. What explains this?

- A. The House of Representatives chose the President because the race was close.
- B. The popular vote decides, so the result must be an error.
- C. The winner earned a majority of electoral votes, which are awarded state by state, mostly winner-take-all.
- D. High turnout lets electors choose freely.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A proposed amendment setting term limits for members of Congress passed both houses by two-thirds. Polls show 75% public support. So far, 30 of the 50 state legislatures have ratified it. What is its status?

- A. Ratified, because a majority of states approved.
- B. Not yet ratified; 38 states are needed.
- C. It still needs the President's signature.
- D. Ratified, because 75% of the public supports it.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which step is required to propose, not ratify, a constitutional amendment through Congress?

- A. A two-thirds vote in both the House and the Senate
- B. A simple majority in both houses and the President's signature
- C. Approval by three-fourths of the states
- D. A ruling from the Supreme Court

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer D Concept 1

A bill funding rural broadband, ~~backed by a coalition of farm groups~~, is vetoed by the President. The House votes 300-130 to override, and the Senate votes 62-38. What happens?

Target word: override outcome **Decides:** Override needs two-thirds in both chambers; 62 of 100 is short of 67.

A	Confusion set	Confuses a simple majority with the two-thirds override rule.
B	Dropped element	Drops the Senate; both chambers must reach two-thirds.
C	Adjacent category	Courts review laws; they do not settle veto overrides.
D	Correct	The House cleared two-thirds (about 70%), but the Senate did not.

2. Answer D Concept 1 • transfer

Which is a check the federal courts hold over Congress?

Target word: a judicial check on the legislature **Decides:** Courts review laws for constitutionality.

A	Inverted operation	The Senate checks the courts, the reverse direction.
B	Absolute language	Courts rule on constitutionality; they do not rewrite policy at will.
C	Confusion set	The veto is an executive check.
D	Correct	Judicial review lets courts void laws that violate the Constitution.

3. Answer B Concept 2

A state ~~with the nation's 12th largest economy, led by a governor in her second term~~, sets its own high school graduation requirements. Which type of power is the state using?

Target word: type of power **Decides:** Education is not delegated to the national government; it is left to states.

A	Inverted operation	Assigns a state action to the national level.
B	Correct	Powers not given to the national government are reserved to the states.
C	Confusion set	Concurrent powers, like taxing, belong to both levels; setting graduation rules does not.
D	Adjacent category	Enumerated powers are the national government's listed powers.

4. Answer B Concept 2 • transfer

Which of these is a concurrent power held by both the national and state governments?

Target word: pick the concurrent power **Decides:** Both levels may do it.

A	Confusion set	A reserved state power.
B	Correct	Both the nation and the states tax.
C	Absolute language	Federalism divides powers; only some are shared.
D	Adjacent category	An enumerated national power states cannot use.

5. Answer A Concept 3

A state legislature places a special tax only on a federal agency's regional office, ~~which employs 140 people in a historic downtown building~~. The stated goal is to push the office out of the state. How would a court most likely rule?

Target word: state vs. federal conflict **Decides:** A state is targeting a valid federal operation.

A	Correct	Federal law and its operations prevail over conflicting state action.
B	Confusion set	That clause deals with states honoring each other's records.
C	Absolute language	Reserved powers do not include obstructing the national government.
D	Dropped element	Drops the Necessary and Proper Clause, which supports implied powers.

6. Answer D Concept 4

A public university ~~founded in 1890, with a nationally ranked engineering program~~, refuses to admit qualified applicants from one ethnic group. What kind of constitutional issue is this?

Target word: liberty or right **Decides:** Unequal treatment of a group by a public body.

A	Confusion set	No expression is being restricted.
B	Absolute language	Public institutions are bound by equal protection.
C	Adjacent category	Nothing is being searched or seized.
D	Correct	The claim is about equal treatment.

7. Answer C Concept 4 · transfer

Which situation is a civil liberties issue rather than a civil rights issue?

Target word: pick the civil liberty **Decides:** Government limiting an individual freedom.

A	Absolute language	Rights and liberties are different categories.
B	Inverted operation	Unequal treatment of a group is a civil rights issue.
C	Correct	A limit on government power over an individual.
D	Adjacent category	An equal-treatment (civil rights) claim.

8. Answer C Concept 5

A state passes a law punishing newspapers that criticize the governor. A newspaper ~~that has published since 1921 and circulates in two states~~ challenges it. The state argues the First Amendment says only "Congress shall make no law." What is the best response?

Target word: does the First Amendment bind states? **Decides:** Incorporation through the 14th Amendment.

A	Camouflage	Circulation does not decide whether the right applies.
B	Dropped element	Drops the 14th Amendment and incorporation.
C	Correct	Selective incorporation extends most Bill of Rights protections to states.
D	Adjacent category	Reserved powers do not override incorporated rights.

9. Answer A Concept 6

The federal government asks a court to stop a newspaper, ~~which has won three regional journalism awards,~~ from publishing leaked documents about a past military policy. Officials say the story would embarrass the government. How is the court most likely to respond?

Target word: prior restraint standard **Decides:** An order to stop publication in advance.

A	Correct	Blocking publication in advance is rarely allowed.
B	Adjacent category	The ban on prior restraint does not grant immunity afterward.
C	Confusion set	Libel is false, damaging statements about a person.
D	Absolute language	There is no blanket power to censor in advance.

10. Answer C Concept 7

In a presidential election ~~with 66% turnout, the highest in decades,~~ one candidate wins the national popular vote by 2 million votes but loses the presidency. What explains this?

Target word: why the popular-vote winner lost **Decides:** Electoral votes decide, awarded state by state.

A	Adjacent category	The House decides only if no one reaches 270 electoral votes.
B	Confusion set	Confuses the popular vote with the electoral vote.
C	Correct	Narrow wins in many states can outweigh a national margin.
D	Camouflage	Turnout has no effect on how electoral votes are awarded.

11. Answer B Concept 8

A proposed amendment ~~setting term limits for members of Congress~~ passed both houses by two-thirds. ~~Polls show 75% public support.~~ So far, 30 of the 50 state legislatures have ratified it. What is its status?

Target word: ratification status **Decides:** Ratification requires three-fourths of states, 38.

A	Dropped element	Drops the three-fourths requirement.
B	Correct	Three-fourths of 50 rounds up to 38.
C	Adjacent category	The President has no formal role in amendments.
D	Camouflage	Public opinion is not part of ratification.

12. Answer A Concept 8 · transfer

Which step is required to propose, not ratify, a constitutional amendment through Congress?

Target word: proposal threshold **Decides:** Proposal needs two-thirds of both houses.

A	Correct	That is the congressional proposal route.
B	Adjacent category	That is ordinary lawmaking.
C	Inverted operation	That is ratification, the later step.
D	Confusion set	Courts play no part in proposing amendments.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owled.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	4	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	10	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	4	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	6	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	9	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	3	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Checks and balances	Each branch can limit the others: the President vetoes, Congress overrides with two-thirds of both chambers, courts strike down unconstitutional acts.	Thinking a simple majority overrides a veto, or that one chamber is enough.	Vote counts after a veto, or one branch acting against another.
2	Federalism: kinds of power	Enumerated powers are listed for the national government; reserved powers stay with the states (10th Amendment); concurrent powers are shared.	Calling any state action concurrent, or any federal action enumerated.	Who is acting (state or nation) and whether the other level can do the same.
3	Supremacy and implied powers	Valid federal law, including powers implied by the Necessary and Proper Clause, overrides conflicting state law; states cannot tax or obstruct federal operations.	Reading the 10th Amendment as letting states block federal action.	A state targeting a federal office, program or law.
4	Civil liberties vs. civil rights	Civil liberties limit what government can do to individuals (speech, search, religion); civil rights guarantee equal treatment (equal protection).	Calling every constitutional claim a civil liberty.	Government overreach vs. unequal treatment of a group.
5	Selective incorporation	Through the 14th Amendment's Due Process Clause, most Bill of Rights protections apply to state and local governments.	Believing the Bill of Rights limits only Congress.	A state claims the First Amendment names only Congress.
6	Free press and prior restraint	Government orders blocking publication in advance carry a heavy presumption of unconstitutionality.	Assuming leaked or embarrassing material can be stopped before printing.	Government asks a court to stop a story before it runs.
7	The Electoral College	The President is chosen by a majority of electoral votes (270), awarded state by state, mostly winner-take-all.	Assuming the national popular vote decides, or that the House decides close races.	A popular-vote winner who loses the presidency.
8	Amending the Constitution	Proposal by two-thirds of both houses (or a convention called by two-thirds of states); ratification by three-fourths of states (38).	Mixing up proposal and ratification thresholds, or giving the President a role.	A count of states or a vote share for an amendment.

Course scope (public description): American Politics and the U.S. Constitution examines the evolution of representative government in the United States and the changing interpretations of the civil rights and civil liberties protected by the Constitution. This course will give candidates an understanding of the powers of the branches of the federal government, the continual tensions inherent in a federal system, the shifting relationship between state and federal governments, and the interactions between elected officials and the ever-changing electorate. This course will focus on such topics as the role of a free press in a democracy, the impact of changing demographics on American politics, and the debates over and expansion of civil rights. Upon completion of the course, candidates should be able to explain the basic functions of the federal government, describe the forces

that shape American policy and politics, and be better prepared to participate in America's civic institutions. This course has no prerequisite.